Statement of Qualifications

What are the most important qualities that a technology lead should possess? Please describe your experience by giving examples using these qualities.

Qualities I believe a tech lead should have is the ability to communicate clearly to both tech and non-tech savvy individuals/groups, knowing how to quickly identify a problem and its potential cause, and being reliable and approachable. A team that doesn't understand or trust one another will have difficulties providing support in any capacity. If anybody has questions/concerns, they need to feel comfortable bringing it to the attention of the tech lead, and that may also be difficult to do if that lead isn't very approachable. Now if you combine the abilities of a non-communicative team with the traits of a non-approachable leader, is it reasonable to expect stellar results?

These qualities were made clear to me while troubleshooting network and system issues of family and friends, as well as my own HomeLab environment. For example, I was asked once to diagnose why someone wasn't getting the internet speeds that they paid for, which was 2.5Gb down, and I was explaining it to them using overly technical vocabulary. As a result, they were no closer to understanding the issue. I rambled in detail about needing a 2.5Gb rated switch, 2.5Gb NICs, and Cat 5e or Cat6 cables to accommodate the new router. When I just simply said, "Your hardware is a bit out of date. With a few new pieces of gear, and newer cables, your system will be able to handle the speeds you're paying for, and the equipment isn't expensive." Not only was he happy about knowing he wouldn't need to break the bank but easily understood the issue was just old hardware.

It wasn't an experience in a team or professional setting, but it did make me re-evaluate how I responded to questions from someone outside the IT realm. If that kind of interaction were to happen on a regular basis, I now have a much clearer idea of how I should move forward.

Describe what customer service means to you and provide methods for how you would ensure that your customers receive exceptional service.

During my time at Block Advisors as a tax preparer I would receive calls/emails from clients requesting an update on the status of their return, especially the ones that were owed a large refund. Most of those clients weren't happy with the lack of communication. I made the mistake of thinking that once the appointment was over, and the return was filed, that was it. It didn't take long for me to realize it was a critical

mistake on my part and didn’t reflect well on Block Advisors. I thought to myself, “If I were the one expecting a large tax refund, I would appreciate it if I got a call from my preparer with an update." I started making sure to set a weekly reminder on my calendar to get in touch with every client I sat down with and give them an update on the status of their return. Even if it was only a several minute long phone call, they thanked me and appreciated the effort.

Once I made this change, clients started giving recommendations to their family and friends to come see me. My workload picked up during the middle and end of the tax season because I made the decision to provide clients with regular updates. This made me realize that something as simple as a callback can have an extraordinary effect on how clients view our professional relationships. If I had simply remained content to ignore them, then that behavior would have been reflected back towards Block Advisors in the form of complaints or unsatisfactory client reviews, which ultimately would lead to a loss of potential revenue.